

The Legislation of Language in *On Truth and Lying in a Non-Moral Sense*

Although Nietzsche covers an array of topics in this work, there is an overarching message that descends upon his readers. “We only think we are in control.” On the subject of language, it is the very vessel that humans channel this belief of their own autonomy, for the drive to truth is mastered by language. Firstly, humans experience stimuli from the world. Secondly, we make relations between these various stimuli. And lastly, we form generalities on particulars that derive from the fundamental concept. Nietzsche describes these particulars as “metaphors” that inevitably lose their connection to the original. Regarding the greater pursuit of truth, the search becomes wishful thinking. For example, in the Romance languages, we ascribe gender to objects that cannot express it. In biological taxonomy, we create the classification system that these species fall under, the implication being that science and empiricism also play second fiddle to social construction. The existence of multiple languages indicates multiple translations of the senses into sound. This is not to be confused with challenging the existence of axioms in reality. Water has been molecularly constant since the birth of the universe, but in Spanish it is “agua” and in Mandarin it is “shui.” Even though its pragmatic uses are comparable, the cultural and syntactic differences are boundless. Returning to a previous point, the political climate on gender in contemporary discussion has fulfilled one of Nietzsche’s fears. The reversal of master and servant in the relationship between humans and language. Reactionaries often forget the very human and very linguistic origins of gender norms. They have essentialized the non-essential and spiritualized the non-spiritual. The very idea of challenging what defines a man and what defines a woman is like decide to the traditionalist. I may as well tear the stars from the heavens and sunder the divine.